

LIKE A PRAYER

The poetry of Yehuda Amichai.

BY JAMES WOOD



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When we encounter a natural style, Pascal says, we are surprised and delighted, because we expected to find an author and instead found a man. Yehuda Amichai, who died in 2000, at the age of seventy-six, and is still Israel's most celebrated poet, possesses that natural style: a human being speaks, in frequencies audible to all, and the discovery is a spreading delight, a shelter and a steady accompaniment to our own lives. Yes, style is always a performance, and Pascal's adage doesn't preclude the awareness that an author might be performing at being a man, or that the surprising man might still, after everything, be a surprising author. But knowing this only sharpens the pleasure we take in those fortunate writers who, like Yehuda Amichai, are free enough to perform most naturally.

Or maybe we should be more brutal about the whole matter? Some writers are likable, and quite a few are not. Amichai is intensely likable. To read "The Poetry of Yehuda Amichai" (Farrar, Straus & Giroux), an ample new selection edited by Robert Alter, is to leaf through the calendar of a sensibility: in this bright book of life, he writes about war and love, about his mother and father, about his children and his neighbors, about loving the Jews and despairing of the Jews, about shopping for groceries in Jerusalem and the politics of Jerusalem, about sex and about God. There is anger and lament, and at times a high, stark, psalmlike rhetoric. There is much allusion (often to the Bible or to Jewish liturgy). But the prevailing tone—more than a tone, it is a way of

being in the world—is direct, open, simple, hospitable, sensuous, witty. He is often ironic, but his irony is as generous as sincerity: he is always adding, not subtracting. "I don't live like a poet," he once said, "nor do I look like one, and I have the child in me. . . . My escape route to childhood is always open." In Amichai's work, there are many such "escape routes": he has rapid access to all the senses.

How not to love a writer who spoke often about making his poetry "useful," who insisted that each of his books of verse in Hebrew should be published in the same handy format (ten by eighteen centimetres), so that they could easily be carried in a reader's pocket? And how not to love a poet who has Amichai's talent for hummable phrasing? Listen to these athletic descriptions of Jerusalem, a city that provokes him to tournaments of redefinition, in much the same way that God provoked the medieval mystics to their rising arrow showers of description: "Jerusalem, the only city in the world/where the right to vote is granted even to the dead." Jerusalem—"a port city on the shore of eternity." "The Venice of God." "An operation that was left open." These are all from one long poem, called "Jerusalem, 1967." Elsewhere, the city is imagined as a place "full of used Jews"—Jews "used by history/Secondhand Jews, with small flaws, bargains." It is a city—this is from yet another poem—where the summons to prayer is the wail of the fire engine and the ambulance. A place where, from time to time, "a new shipment of history arrives."

This talent for quick, memorable phrase-making is an art of the popular, and one that many poets, strangely enough, lack. It is an element of Amichai's ordinary vitality, the current that connects him to contemporary songwriters and antique balladeers. (In Israel, his poems have been used by musicians, and also by advertisers.) Occasionally, he abuses this facility: one can tire of the easy way in which he likens God to a tour guide (twice), or to a mechanic endlessly fixing the world; or Jacob to a "window washer to the VIPs," carrying a ladder on his back. But the talent for likening God to a tour guide is related to the talent that comes up with this: "The war broke out in the fall, at the empty border/between grapes and citrus

fruit." And: "every day of our life together/Ecclesiastes cancels a line of his book." Or this: "You had a laughter of grapes:/ many round green laughs." Or this: "And who will remember the rememberers?" This line about remembering the rememberers could be a slogan on a political or commercial poster, while the image of Jerusalem being full of "used Jews" might have come from an indie-rock song. The beautiful line about war breaking out on the border between grapes and citrus fruit may seem more considered or more original (or just more lyrical and, hence, more "poetic"), but it belongs to the same voice, the same mouth, as a laugh is related to a yawn.

Amichai's art is as appealing in its depths as in its shallows. His metaphors are more active than those of most poets. First of all, they are colossally various. He has a psalmlike register, in which laughter is like grapes, eyes are like figs, and the poet recalls his father thus: "the rivers of his hands/poured into his good deeds," and his mother like this: "I want to walk through / the deep ravines between her sobs." More often, he makes joyous and strange analogies, stretching his similes into twisted lengths of elastic wit. In "Songs of Zion the Beautiful," a long poem in which he quarrels and plays with the city in which he spent most of his life, he anatomizes its "Wailing Wall, towers, rusty halos, / all the prophecies that—like old men—couldn't hold it in."

In a tender poem about his parents, he remembers them, from the distance of his middle age, as resembling the "simple toys of my childhood," turning in circles, humming softly, raising a leg, moving slowly from side to side with the same rhythm, "the spring in their belly and the key in their back. / Then suddenly they stop moving and remain/ forever in their last position." In "My Parents' Migration," which reflects on his family's displacement from Germany (where Amichai was born), houses are "always/ Like ships," because nothing stays in place.

One of my favorite of Amichai's inventive likenesses occurs in a beautiful poem addressed to his young son. It has no title and is simply numbered "69," in a volume entitled "Time," which appeared in 1977; it was translated by Amichai and his great friend and admirer

the poet Ted Hughes. It's a bar-mitzvah poem, a blessing. Amichai begs to kiss his son once more, "while you still love it," while the boy is still a soft-skinned Jacob and before he becomes "a hairy Esau of open fields." He writes that "I'm on my way from believing in God/ and you're on your way toward it," and that this is a meeting point between father and son. In the final verse, he offers his formal blessing: evening falls, and the land is cooling, and "clouds that have never lain with a woman/pass overhead in the sky"; the desert is breathing, "and all the generations/squeeze a bar mitzvah for you." Lucky son! So many of Amichai's qualities gather here: passionate tenderness and earnest warmth, sweet possessiveness—the eros of fatherhood—and that delicious, playful metaphorical reach, those clouds that have never lain with a woman. What would those clouds look like? The metaphor can't be a visual similitude (although white, gauzy clouds could look somehow more virginal than heavy ones pregnant with rain). The metaphor—as similitude—almost "fails," but it is blazingly successful in the context of the poem's address to a young man who has not yet "lain with a woman." And, of course, the diction gently picks up the Biblical thread of the reference to Jacob and Esau, a story that begins with a father's blessing.

But plenty of writers can conjure exciting similitudes. Amichai's genius lies in how—to borrow from his own language—he makes metaphor "useful." He thinks metaphorically, and in so doing he makes stories of them, treating his likenesses as if they were not metaphorical but animated literalisms. That's why, I suspect, his metaphors have not merely poetic power but practical vitality, in the way that a horse is not only alive but usefully alive. In "Jerusalem, 1967" (translated in this volume by Stephen Mitchell), there is a verse in which Amichai begins by describing the city as "short and crouched among its hills," unlike, say, tall New York. Then he makes an animated metaphorical fiction of his original metaphor (or personification): "Two thousand years ago she crouched / in the marvelous starting-line position." All the other cities ran ahead, did "laps in the arena of time," had their victories or defeats. But "Jerusalem remained in the

starting crouch:/ all the victories are clenched inside her,/ hidden inside her. All the defeats." Amichai glides quickly between his own poetic suggestions, and this supple navigation credits his inventions with the otherness of their existence: he proceeds as if his own metaphors had the naturalness of found things, not the artifice of made things. In "Leah Goldberg Died," a tribute to a poet of an earlier generation who championed his work, the hollow of an eye socket easily becomes the hollow of a grave:

Her sad eyes are the only ones
that could compete with my father's eyes
in the ancient Jewish game
of heavy eyes sliding into
hollows beneath.
(Now they are both there.)

And see what he does with the lowly hyphen in "Late Marriage" (about his second marriage, to Hana Sokolov; this version is by Chana Bloch). Amichai starts in his usual modest, accessible way—he is sitting in a waiting room, with bridegrooms who are much younger than the poet. The poet has "heavy steps" but "light thoughts," as opposed to when he was a young man, and carried thoughts "heavy with destiny/ on light feet that almost danced from so much future." Then, in an extended act of figuration worthy of John Donne, Amichai reflects that the pressure of his life has brought his date of birth closer to the date of his death, "as in history books/ where the pressure of history has brought/ those two numbers together next to the name of a dead king/ with only a hyphen between them." And suddenly this figure of the hyphen takes on palpable life, for it is this little temporal bridge which the poet, oldish but renewed by his late marriage, now fiercely cherishes:

I hold onto that hyphen with all my might
like a lifeline, I live on it,
and on my lips the vow not to be alone,
the voice of the bridegroom and the voice
of the bride,
the sound of the children laughing and
shouting
in the streets of Jerusalem
and in the cities of Yehuda.

Although I have quoted freely, so as to voice the melody of Amichai, I should not give the impression that he was only a lyric singer of the self and not also a religious and political debater; or that

the allusive and colloquial Hebrew of the poems can be carried over into English without leakage. I have a sense of how that melody sounds in English, but how does it sound in Hebrew? Robert Alter's scrupulous introduction, and the presence, in "The Poetry of Yehuda Amichai," of no fewer than fourteen different translators (with many new versions by Alter), reminds us that translation is arduous, necessary, and unfinished. Many of Amichai's references, puns, jokes, buried meanings—the creases of a culture, its age lines—are inevitably smoothed out of existence in translation.

The reader without Hebrew fumbles among cleaned remnants; makes do with hand-me-downs. There are beautiful poemlike forms in this book (Alter, Leon Wieseltier, Mitchell, Chana Bloch, and Chana Kronfeld earn one's particular admiration as interpreters), but I cannot judge them as translations. The line breaks sometimes appear, by the standards of English verse, almost arbitrary; so the reader shrugs and converts, happily enough, those poems into pieces of broken prose. Alter is rightly celebrated both for his translations from the Hebrew and for his scholarship. His ferociously annotated versions of the Pentateuch and of the Psalms chaperone the Hebrew-less reader through many dense cruxes. Alas, there is no such help in this volume; the fairly sparse notes at the back do little more than point to well-known landmarks, and the reader

keen to resolve lexical puzzles has to go elsewhere, to commentary by other scholars.

Context is especially important in understanding Yehuda Amichai's work, because he draws so freely on the events of his life, and because his work is closely associated with the emergence of modern Israel. He was born in 1924, in Würzburg, a Bavarian town with a large and important Jewish community. The household that he grew up in was Orthodox and Zionist, an inheritance he honored throughout his writing, even as he abandoned its formal religious beliefs and practices as a young man. He once said that his work, rich in theological struggle and plaint, merely continued a discussion he had with his father: "We loved each other very much, but we had this problem—big problem—so we go on, I go on discussing it with him. . . . When I was a child, like every child, I thought my father was really a god, and when I rebelled against him, he still was God. But then I found out, of course, that he was a human being. I think it's the same with God."

The Pfeuffers, as they were then named, left for Palestine in the mid-nineteen-thirties—children, parents, and many aunts and uncles—a happy example of a large extended family surviving intact. Amichai served in the Jewish Brigade of the British Army during the Second World War, alert to the irony that his enemy was now the German Army,

in which his father had served during the First World War. He fought in the 1948-49 Israeli War of Independence, at the Negev front, where combat was intense, and again in 1956. In such poems as "Not Like a Cypress" and "I Want to Die in My Bed," both from a collection published in 1958, Amichai declined the role of military victor or glamorous hero. He would not, he announced, stand tall like a cypress tree, but preferred to be like the grass, "in thousands of cautious green exits." He would not be Joshua, or Saul, or Samson; he just wanted to die in his bed.

His work, like his life, is closely bound up with contemporary Israeli life. His poems have been called the nation's "secular prayers." He is quoted at funerals and weddings, in political speeches and ceremonies, in rabbinical sermons and in a Jewish American prayer book. The Israeli journalist Eilat Negev tells the story of how Amichai was once watching a soldier's funeral on TV only to discover that the woman standing over the grave was reading from his poem "God Full of Mercy," his fiercely ironic version of the "El Malei Rachamim," the memorial prayer recited at funerals and on certain holidays. There is no counterpart to this popularity in American letters, though perhaps Robert Frost once approached it.

In her new book, "The Full Severity of Compassion: The Poetry of Yehuda Amichai" (Stanford), the scholar and translator Chana Kronfeld writes acutely of how Israeli (and Jewish American) appropriations of Amichai's work have often robbed it of its complicated theological allusiveness and its political radicalism. In a series of crystalline readings, she restores to his poetry its cultural dangerousness. When poems become secular prayers, reverence tends to rub away their edges. She argues, for instance, that "I Want to Die in My Bed" has too often been read as a piece of liberal quietism—the private citizen who simply prefers to retire from extended military engagements. She notes how the poem, with its mock-heroic abuse of Samson and Joshua, and lines like "Your light/ Sees fit to shine for war makers who murder all night," refuses and resists "the new, muscular image of Jewish masculinity." Indeed, Amichai's verse often sets itself against nationalistic narratives. The poet



"What about selling drugs to the rich and keeping the money for ourselves?"

always has, as he puts it, “the face of the conquered painted in the colors of the conqueror.” In “Songs of Zion the Beautiful,” a long celebration of Jerusalem continually curdles into defiance, lament, elegy. The poet finds himself yearning for the old, divided city. United, Jerusalem has returned to “her fat legitimate life./ But I don’t love her./ I sometimes remember the quiet one.” In “Jews in the Land of Israel,” he asks, “What are we doing / in this dark land with its/ yellow shadows that pierce the eyes?” He concludes that “spilled blood is not the root of trees / but it’s the closest thing to roots/ we have.”

Those last lines are characteristic of Amichai’s probing, ambidextrous politics, and suggest how different political camps might claim for themselves the same liberalism. On the one hand, Amichai describes nothing more than anguished historical fact: Israel as a country founded on spilled European blood and transferred pain. But another transferred pain lurks in the lines, the spilled blood of those displaced by the establishment of Israel, and to announce that one’s country is pooled in blood might be thought to hack bloodily at its legitimacy. Yet again, and against that pessimistic reading, there is merely stoic accommodation in Amichai’s words: this is what we have, and we will have to make do with it.

Some will find this politics, though compassionate and deeply liberal, too muted. Amichai tends to see Palestinians (insofar as they make any distinct appearance in his work) as, precisely, Other. In his weaker writing, there creeps into the verse a slightly reflexive, choric fatalism, a sacralizing of the land’s conflicts, in which Israel is evoked as a place haplessly soaked in thousands of years of religious strife: “In my land, called holy, / they won’t let eternity be: / they’ve divided it into little religions, / zoned it for God-zones.” But who, in these words, is “they”? “Jewish history and world history / grind me between them,” he writes, as if the soldier-poet, who helped found his nation, lacked all political agency.

The lines about the Holy Land being zoned for religion (by mysterious agents) ring slightly false, in part because Amichai’s personal religious zone—a veritable switchboard of complaint—is so lit

up with his own blasphemous electricity. No contemporary writer known to me has written as searchingly and complicatedly about God and the ghost of God, and with such rich mixtures of feeling, such brazen anguish and play. Like Jerusalem (but more so), God provokes Amichai to describe and re-describe, shatters his language into splintered approximations.

When Amichai is angry, he reaches for savage inversions: as we once hid from God in the Garden of Eden, now God hides from us (“And That Is Your Glory”). The age of sacrificing animals to God has passed, and instead it is we who sacrifice ourselves to God (“Those Were Days of Grace”). God may be “full of mercy” (liturgical words from the prayer for the dead), but he hogs all the available mercy for himself, and “Were God not full of mercy / there would be mercy in the world, and not just in Him” (“God Full of Mercy”). If, Amichai says, I believed in God, I wouldn’t tell him about the wars I have fought in, “as one doesn’t tell a child about the grown-ups’ horrors” (“What I Learned in the Wars”). God is like a rich, spoiled “only God,” akin to an only child (a fabulously ironic identity for the God who invented monotheism).

These fruitful negations are the fated language of a man for whom God, like time, is always present and always gone. And these gestures and quarrels are more than the merely familiar struggle of the atheist who constantly invokes a God he does not believe in. Amichai does not believe in God, and does not want him back—but what has belief got to do with it, if (in the Feuerbachian sense) we invented him anyway? How to uninvent him? How to purge him from our grammar? Gods change, but prayers are here to stay, as the title of one of Amichai’s poems slyly has it.

Besides, the God of the Jews—the “only God” of an only people—is a national possession, not just a theological one. If God disappears, do the Jews disappear? Perhaps the threat also exists the other way round? In several poems, Amichai gives expression to a fear that the Jews and their God might go down together, united in oblivion. Perhaps he will “forget not his own,” but perhaps it’s too late: “the Jewish people is gone.” What does a father do, Amichai asks, in “Gods

Change, Prayers Are Here to Stay,” when “his children are orphans and he / is still alive?” And what will a father do when his children are all dead and he becomes “a bereaved father for all eternity?”

In the same magnificent poem, Amichai despairingly proposes a new, post-Auschwitz theology, in which God’s dead people, those who died in the Shoah, now resemble their dead God, the deity ideally described by Maimonides as having “no likeness of a body and . . . no body.” God is at once the designer (or, at best, a voyeur) of the Holocaust and its most famous victim, destined to disappear in smoke, like his murdered people. The philosopher Emil Fackenheim once proposed, after Auschwitz, what he called a “614th commandment,” in which the Jewish people are enjoined to survive as Jews, lest the people of Israel perish; commanded to remember the Holocaust, lest that memory perish; and “forbidden, thirdly, to deny or despair of God . . . lest Judaism perish.” Amichai is sympathetically alert to Fackenheim’s tragic anxiety. But, cheerfully and despondently, comically and tragically, reverently and heretically, he breaks—because he must be free to break—Fackenheim’s fearful commandment.

It is the cheerfulness that lingers here behind the lines, like a happy schoolboy, as world history continues its stolid death march. Amichai has many modes, but a faithful and fortifying humanism is his commonest and his most delightful. He ends a poem in this volume with characteristic pleasure: employing the presence of God only to displace him, he puns humanely on “His” and “his.” In Rome, the poet says, he once saw a woman waiting at a corner. He adds that he doesn’t know how long the woman stood there, or whether the person she was waiting for turned up. But, he continues, “after her death” God will “gently pry open her head, as He always does,” to seek “the name of the one she truly loved.” And? “And it won’t be His name, it won’t be His.” Amichai is a man who, as he once playfully put it, rebelled only a little, because he did, after all, observe the laws and the Commandments—the laws, he quickly adds, of gravity and equilibrium, and the horror of the vacuum. Which is to say, he belongs not only to Israel and to the Hebrew language but to all of us. ♦